# 2004 Hyundai Sonata LX

$2,500 · 143,000 miles · Private seller · Ridgecrest, CA

Seller: Private seller

Source: Facebook Marketplace

Listing: https://www.facebook.com/marketplace/item/1724944808597038/

Report generated October 27, 2026 · Ridgecrest Car Finder



| Out-the-door price | Monthly cost to own | Reliability |
|---|---|---|
| **$2,902** | **$451** | **Average** |
| Set a budget in the Cost Calculator tab to compare. | loan + insurance + fuel + repairs + registration | 3/5 · 1 recalls · 202 NHTSA complaints |

## Budget — buying it

| | |
|---|---|
| Vehicle price | $2,500.00 |
| Use tax (9.25%) — paid at DMV | $231.25 |
| Vehicle license fee (0.65% of price) | $16.25 |
| Registration + CHP fee | $108.00 |
| Transportation improvement fee | $32.00 |
| Title transfer | $15.00 |
| Total out-the-door | $2,902.50 |
| + Pre-purchase inspection (you pay the shop) | $150.00 |

California taxes the full price — a trade-in does not reduce sales tax. DMV fees are estimates; the CA DMV fee calculator gives exact amounts.

## Budget — paying for it

| | |
|---|---|
| Down payment | $2,902.50 |
| Amount financed | $0.00 |
| Cash needed up front (down payment + inspection) | $3,052.50 |

Paid in full with your down payment — no loan needed.

## Budget — owning it each month

| | |
|---|---|
| Loan payment | $0.00 |
| Insurance (estimate, liability) | $70.00 |
| Fuel (1,000 mi/mo @ 20 MPG, $4.75/gal) | $237.50 |
| Maintenance & repair reserve | $130.00 |
| Registration renewal (÷12) | $13.85 |
| Total per month | $451.35 |

Running costs without the loan: **$451/mo**. Estimated first-year cost of ownership: **$8,469** (out-the-door + inspection + 12 months of running costs + loan interest).

The repair reserve is set from the reliability rating and mileage: money to set aside, not a forecast.

## Insurance

| Coverage | Typical Ridgecrest range | Estimate used |
|---|---|---|
| Liability only (CA minimum 30/60/15) | $49–$112/mo | $70/mo |
| Full coverage (liability + collision + comprehensive) | $94–$243/mo | $135/mo |

The budget above uses the **liability coverage** estimate ($70/mo). Get real quotes and enter one in the app to replace it.

• Vehicle class: typical car. Estimates assume an adult driver with a clean record; age, record, credit, and coverage limits change the price a lot.

• Ridgecrest is one of the cheapest places in California to insure a car (about $107–110/mo average).

• A lender will require full coverage. On an older, cheap car paid in cash, liability-only can make sense — but you'd pay for your own repairs after an at-fault accident.

• California's minimum (30/60/15) is low; $100k/$300k/$100k liability is commonly recommended.

• Ask about military/government discounts (NAWS China Lake), bundling, and low-mileage discounts.

## Reliability

**Rating: Average (3/5)**

Average. The 2004 Sonata is a simple, cheap-to-fix car, but at 143k with a V6 (17 city MPG) it's a short-term option. 202 NHTSA complaints, mostly suspension and body structure.

NHTSA data for this model year: 1 recalls · 202 owner complaints (22 involving a crash). Most complaints: Suspension (56), Structure (47), Air Bags (46), Electrical System (17), Service Brakes (16), Steering (13).

**Known issues for this model**

• Timing belt must be replaced on schedule (~60k miles) - a snapped belt strands you

• Front lower control arm / subframe corrosion recall (09V-124)

• Crank or cam position sensor failures (stalling)

• Passenger airbag occupant-sensor faults

**Check on this car before buying**

• Ask for timing belt replacement records

- Run VIN: was the suspension recall done?
- Check for a lit airbag warning light
- Seller must provide a smog certificate

## Notes

$2,500 (was $3,500), 143k mi, automatic, white/tan, likely the 2.7L V6 (listing shows 17 city MPG). 1 owner, clean title. Seller: no issues, runs perfectly, brand new tires; some seat damage and front bumper paint damage.

Cheapest clean-title car in town - a short-term 'bridge car' option.

2026-10-23: LISTING REMOVED - no longer on Facebook Marketplace (likely sold).

## Vetting checklist (0/12 done)

- [ ] Checked KBB/Edmunds fair price
- [ ] Recalls checked / completed
- [ ] Clean title in seller's name
- [ ] Test drive incl. highway & hills
- [ ] No overheating; coolant clean
- [ ] Pre-purchase inspection
- [ ] VIN decoded & matches listing
- [ ] History report (Carfax/AutoCheck/NMVTIS)
- [ ] Valid smog cert (< 90 days)
- [ ] A/C cold after 15+ min
- [ ] Tires OK (tread, dry-rot, DOT date)
- [ ] Written out-the-door price

All costs and insurance figures are estimates for planning, not quotes. Confirm fees with the CA DMV, rates with insurers, and the car's condition with an independent pre-purchase inspection.